

Classic Style Seeds

Imitation workbook

Aim: write like a reader who has listened carefully. Each page gives a tiny classic seed, then asks you to transpose the craft into your own words.

Rule: never paste the original quotation into your story. Use a new subject, new setting and new details.

Contents

Each numbered seed has its own practice page in the workbook.

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Mixed practice tests: final pages combine several techniques in one task.

1. Character - sharp portraits

"a squeezing, wrenching, grasping, scraping, clutching, covetous old sinner"

Charles Dickens, A Christmas Carol

Technique to borrow: Stack five related actions before the noun.

Frame: a [verb-ing], [verb-ing], [verb-ing] sort of [person]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a greedy, vain or lazy character without using the words greedy, vain or lazy.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

2. Atmosphere - weather and mood

"Fog everywhere"

Charles Dickens, Bleak House

Technique to borrow: Name one dominant thing and make it feel everywhere.

Frame: [Noun] everywhere.

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a school corridor where one smell, sound or colour seems to take over everything.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

3. Landscape - line and distance

"a long black horizontal line"

Charles Dickens, Great Expectations

Technique to borrow: Reduce a place to shape plus colour.

Frame: a [length] [colour] [shape] of [place]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a distant forest, road, river or skyline in one clean visual line.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

4. Openings - contrast

"It was the best of times, it was the worst of times"

Charles Dickens, A Tale of Two Cities

Technique to borrow: Pair two opposites in the same structure.

Frame: It was the [best] of [things], it was the [worst] of [things]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Open a story about a new school, holiday or competition with a balanced contrast.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

5. Voice - irony

"a single man in possession of a good fortune"

Jane Austen, Pride and Prejudice

Technique to borrow: Use serious phrasing for a slightly ridiculous idea.

Frame: a [person] in possession of [object/status]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Write an ironic first line about someone arriving with a new phone, trophy or attitude.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

6. Character - compressed summary

"handsome, clever, and rich"

Jane Austen, Emma

Technique to borrow: Choose three precise adjectives that do real work.

Frame: [adjective], [adjective], and [adjective]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Introduce a character in exactly three adjectives, then prove one of them with an action.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

7. Character - moral diagnosis

"vanity was the beginning and the end"

Jane Austen, Persuasion

Technique to borrow: Make one trait dominate a character's world.

Frame: [trait] was the beginning and the end

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a character ruled by envy, pride, fear or kindness.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

8. Openings - immediate obstacle

"There was no possibility of taking a walk that day"

Charlotte Bronte, Jane Eyre

Technique to borrow: Open with something impossible.

Frame: There was no possibility of [ordinary action] that day.

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Begin a scene by making one ordinary thing impossible.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

9. Landscape - pale weather

"a pale blank of mist and cloud"

Charlotte Bronte, Jane Eyre

Technique to borrow: Use one colour and one abstract noun for the sky.

Frame: a [colour] blank of [weather]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a window view that matches a bored or lonely mood.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

10. Character - comic judgement

"a perfect misanthropist's heaven"

Emily Bronte, Wuthering Heights

Technique to borrow: Define a place by the person who would enjoy it.

Frame: a perfect [type of person]'s heaven

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a room that would delight a gossip, a coward or a show-off.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

11. Emotion - fear arriving

"the intense horror of nightmare came over me"

Emily Bronte, Wuthering Heights

Technique to borrow: Make an emotion move towards or over a character.

Frame: the [emotion] of [image] came over me

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Show panic arriving in a character's body.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

12. Emotion - shattered hope

"the beauty of the dream vanished"

Mary Shelley, Frankenstein

Technique to borrow: Let a hopeful image disappear in one verb.

Frame: the beauty of the [hope] vanished

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Write the moment when excitement turns into dread.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

13. Emotion - body and disgust

"breathless horror and disgust filled my heart"

Mary Shelley, Frankenstein

Technique to borrow: Combine a physical state with a moral feeling.

Frame: [physical feeling] [emotion] and [emotion] filled my [body part]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe shame, jealousy or fear entering the body.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

14. Setting - sensory detail

"the rich odour of roses"

Oscar Wilde, The Picture of Dorian Gray

Technique to borrow: Start a scene with scent.

Frame: the [texture] odour of [thing]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Open a room description with a smell that hints at mood.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

15. Symbol - colour thread

"scarlet threads of life"

Oscar Wilde, The Picture of Dorian Gray

Technique to borrow: Turn an idea into a coloured thread, stain or mark.

Frame: [colour] threads of [idea]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe guilt, hope or jealousy as a colour moving through a scene.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

16. Atmosphere - sinister buildings

"a certain sinister block of building"

Robert Louis Stevenson, Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde

Technique to borrow: Place one charged adjective before an ordinary noun.

Frame: a certain [threatening adjective] [ordinary object]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe an ordinary door, cupboard or staircase so it feels dangerous.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

17. Character - visual shorthand

"the brown old seaman"

Robert Louis Stevenson, Treasure Island

Technique to borrow: Use colour, age and role in one phrase.

Frame: the [colour] old [role]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Introduce a stranger entering a room in five words.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

18. Voice - surprise

"curiouser and curiouser"

Lewis Carroll, Alice's Adventures in Wonderland

Technique to borrow: Bend a word when ordinary grammar is too tidy.

Frame: [adjective]-er and [adjective]-er

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Invent a playful phrase for a situation becoming stranger.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

19. Image - impossible detail

"a grin without a cat"

Lewis Carroll, Alice's Adventures in Wonderland

Technique to borrow: Detach one feature from the thing it belongs to.

Frame: a [feature] without a [owner]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Create a magical or comic image using the pattern feature without owner.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

20. Atmosphere - confinement

"The castle is a veritable prison"

Bram Stoker, Dracula

Technique to borrow: Rename a place as what it feels like.

Frame: The [place] is a veritable [trap/image].

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a classroom, lift or waiting room as a trap.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

21. Landscape - sea metaphor

"a sea of green tree tops"

Bram Stoker, Dracula

Technique to borrow: Turn a mass of objects into a sea.

Frame: a sea of [colour] [things]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a crowd, forest or city as a sea.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

22. Character - eyes

"his eyes were sharp and piercing"

Arthur Conan Doyle, A Study in Scarlet

Technique to borrow: Use two adjectives that point to mental qualities.

Frame: his/her eyes were [adjective] and [adjective]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a detective, teacher or rival through their eyes.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

23. Character - inner label

"his whole Bohemian soul"

Arthur Conan Doyle, The Adventures of Sherlock Holmes

Technique to borrow: Give a character a noun for the soul.

Frame: his/her whole [quality/group] soul

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Invent a compact soul phrase for a messy genius, quiet dreamer or fierce friend.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

24. Openings - dramatic denial

"No one would have believed"

H. G. Wells, *The War of the Worlds*

Technique to borrow: Begin by denying that anyone expected the event.

Frame: No one would have believed [event].

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Open a science-fiction or school disaster scene with this pattern.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

25. Movement - light and dark

"The twinkling succession of darkness and light"

H. G. Wells, *The Time Machine*

Technique to borrow: Use a succession of opposites.

Frame: a [flickering/twinkling] succession of [opposite] and [opposite]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe passing lights, memories or emotions using a succession of opposites.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

26. Atmosphere - gothic weather

"a dull, dark, and soundless day"

Edgar Allan Poe, The Fall of the House of Usher

Technique to borrow: Choose three adjectives, with at least two sharing a sound.

Frame: a [sound-linked], [sound-linked], and [silent] day

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a day before something frightening happens.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

27. Openings - rhythm

"Once upon a midnight dreary"

Edgar Allan Poe, The Raven

Technique to borrow: Move the adjective after the noun for an old-fashioned effect.

Frame: Once upon a [time] [adjective]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Open a spooky scene with rhythm and an unusual word order.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

28. Symbol - beauty beside danger

"a wild rose-bush"

Nathaniel Hawthorne, *The Scarlet Letter*

Technique to borrow: Put a beautiful object beside a harsh place.

Frame: a [beautiful wild thing] beside [harsh place]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Place one beautiful detail beside a prison, hospital, exam hall or battlefield.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

29. Atmosphere - sleepy sound

"a drowsy, dreamy influence"

Washington Irving, The Legend of Sleepy Hollow

Technique to borrow: Use sound to make atmosphere.

Frame: a [sound-linked], [sound-linked] influence

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a village, classroom or garden with two sleepy-sounding adjectives.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

30. Emotion - weather inside

"a damp, drizzly November in my soul"

Herman Melville, Moby-Dick

Technique to borrow: Put weather inside the person.

Frame: a [weather] [month/season] in my soul

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe boredom, worry or excitement as weather inside someone.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

31. Openings - direct address

"Call me Ishmael"

Herman Melville, Moby-Dick

Technique to borrow: Start with a command that gives a name.

Frame: Call me [name].

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Write three different first lines that introduce a narrator quickly.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

32. Voice - direct confidence

"You don't know about me"

Mark Twain, Adventures of Huckleberry Finn

Technique to borrow: Begin by challenging the reader's knowledge.

Frame: You don't know about [person/thing].

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Write a narrator's first sentence that sounds alive, not formal.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

33. Character - buried instinct

"the dominant primordial beast was strong in Buck"

Jack London, The Call of the Wild

Technique to borrow: Use an ancient-sounding adjective for an instinct.

Frame: the [ancient adjective] [instinct/feeling] was strong in [name]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a hidden instinct waking in a character.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

34. Landscape - wide opening

"The sea-reach of the Thames stretched before us"

Joseph Conrad, Heart of Darkness

Technique to borrow: Choose a verb that makes the view expand.

Frame: The [place] stretched before us.

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Open a journey scene with one wide view.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

35. Society - small world

"Archer's little world"

Edith Wharton, *The Age of Innocence*

Technique to borrow: Call a group or family a world.

Frame: [Name]'s little world

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a school year group, family or club as its own world.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

36. Tension - held attention

"The story had held us"

Henry James, *The Turn of the Screw*

Technique to borrow: Let an abstract thing hold the listener.

Frame: The [story/secret/silence] had held us.

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a secret or rumour gripping a room.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

37. Character - animal comparison

"a cygnet is reared uneasily among the ducklings"

George Eliot, Middlemarch

Technique to borrow: Use a young animal among plainer animals.

Frame: a [young graceful animal] among [ordinary animals]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact word from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a child who does not fit their surroundings.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

38. Abstract - power imagined

"a shadowy conception of power"

George Eliot, *Silas Marner*

Technique to borrow: Give an abstract idea a visual adjective.

Frame: a [visual adjective] conception of [abstract noun]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a child's idea of justice, fame or danger.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

39. Character - time on a face

"A Face on Which Time Makes but Little Impression"

Thomas Hardy, *The Return of the Native*

Technique to borrow: Let time act on a person physically.

Frame: a face on which time had [verb] [effect]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe an old or strangely young-looking face.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

40. Landscape - absence

"the forests have departed"

Thomas Hardy, Tess of the d'Urbervilles

Technique to borrow: Make a missing part of the landscape actively depart.

Frame: the [natural thing] had departed

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a place that has lost something important.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

41. Setting - industrial compression

"this big smoky place"

Elizabeth Gaskell, *North and South*

Technique to borrow: Use one physical adjective that carries social meaning.

Frame: this big [physical adjective] place

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a town, station or market in four words.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

42. Mystery - visual label

"the woman in white"

Wilkie Collins, The Woman in White

Technique to borrow: Name a character by a striking colour or object.

Frame: the [person] in [colour/object]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Invent a mysterious stranger using a colour tag.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

43. Mystery - object focus

"the yellow Diamond"

Wilkie Collins, *The Moonstone*

Technique to borrow: Give an object colour and status.

Frame: the [colour] [object]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Introduce a stolen, magical or forbidden object in three words.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

44. Character - frank judgement

"the most disagreeable-looking child ever seen"

Frances Hodgson Burnett, *The Secret Garden*

Technique to borrow: Use a bold judgement, then prove it with detail.

Frame: the most [adjective]-looking [person] ever seen

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a character with a strong judgement, then soften it with one human detail.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

45. Landscape - childlike naming

"the White Way of Delight"

L. M. Montgomery, Anne of Green Gables

Technique to borrow: Rename a place according to the emotion it gives.

Frame: the [Colour] Way of [Emotion]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Give a boring route a poetic name and explain why.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

46. Openings - ordinary before magic

"The Mole had been working very hard all the morning"

Kenneth Grahame, *The Wind in the Willows*

Technique to borrow: Begin with work before wonder enters.

Frame: The [character] had been [ordinary action] all the morning.

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Begin a scene with an ordinary chore that leads to adventure.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

47. Openings - universal rule

"All children, except one, grow up"

J. M. Barrie, Peter Pan

Technique to borrow: State a general rule, then break it.

Frame: All [group], except one, [ordinary truth].

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Invent an opening rule for a fantasy story.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

48. Sound - playful geography

"the great grey-green, greasy Limpopo River"

Rudyard Kipling, Just So Stories

Technique to borrow: Repeat a sound across colour, size and texture.

Frame: the [size] [colour-colour], [texture] [place]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a river, corridor or playground with repeated sounds.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

49. Action - animal strength

"Bagheera's eyes were as hard as jade stones"

Rudyard Kipling, The Jungle Book

Technique to borrow: Show danger through a precise comparison.

Frame: [character]'s eyes were as hard as [stone/object]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Show that someone or something is dangerous without saying dangerous.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

50. Character - shy radiance

"She was a Phantom of delight"

William Wordsworth, Poems

Technique to borrow: Turn a person into a striking abstract image.

Frame: She/He was a [image] of [emotion]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe someone who seems ordinary to others but magical to the narrator.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

51. Landscape - simile

"I wandered lonely as a cloud"

William Wordsworth, Poems in Two Volumes

Technique to borrow: Choose a natural object that moves like the feeling.

Frame: I [verb] [emotion] as a [natural thing].

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Write three similes for loneliness, excitement and guilt.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

52. Landscape - seasonal abundance

"Season of mists and mellow fruitfulness"

John Keats, Poems Published in 1820

Technique to borrow: Use sound to create softness or richness.

Frame: Season of [weather] and [adjective noun]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe winter, spring or exam season as if it were a person or kingdom.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

53. Movement - alliteration

"The fair breeze blew, the white foam flew"

Samuel Taylor Coleridge, The Rime of the Ancient Mariner

Technique to borrow: Repeat grammar and sound across two clauses.

Frame: The [adjective noun] [verb], the [adjective noun] [verb].

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe running, rain or a crowd with paired alliteration.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

54. Image - bright danger

"Tyger Tyger, burning bright"

William Blake, Songs of Experience

Technique to borrow: Repeat the subject, then give it a dangerous glow.

Frame: [Thing] [thing], [burning/gleaming] [adjective]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a beautiful object that also feels threatening.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

55. Landscape - river opening

"On either side the river lie"

Alfred Tennyson, The Lady of Shalott

Technique to borrow: Move the verb to make a line sound formal or mythic.

Frame: On either side the [place] [verb]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a path, river or road with slightly formal word order.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

56. Emotion - poisoned mind

"full of scorpions is my mind"

William Shakespeare, Macbeth

Technique to borrow: Put a dangerous creature inside an abstract place.

Frame: full of [creatures] is my [mind/heart]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe guilt, worry or anger as creatures inside the body.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

57. Ending - brief life

"Out, out, brief candle"

William Shakespeare, Macbeth

Technique to borrow: Make life, hope or courage into a fragile flame.

Frame: Out, out, brief [light/object]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Write a dark sentence where hope disappears suddenly.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

58. Character - radiant comparison

"Juliet is the sun"

William Shakespeare, Romeo and Juliet

Technique to borrow: Make one person change the lighting of a place.

Frame: [Name] is the [source of light].

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a person entering a room and changing its mood.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

59. Action - unleashed violence

"let slip the dogs of war"

William Shakespeare, Julius Caesar

Technique to borrow: Turn a conflict into something released.

Frame: let slip the [creatures] of [conflict]

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe an argument or match beginning as if something has been unleashed.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

60. Magic - dream substance

"such stuff as dreams are made on"

William Shakespeare, The Tempest

Technique to borrow: Turn an abstract experience into material.

Frame: such stuff as [dreams/fears/memories] are made on

Memory check: cover the quote, then write the exact seed from memory.

Transposition drill: keep the structure, change the subject completely.

Writing prompt: Describe a place or moment that feels unreal but precious.

Teacher/self check: Is the new sentence original? Does it use the same technique? Is the image precise?

Mixed practice tests

1. Describe an intimidating teacher using alliteration, a colour tag and one precise eye detail.

2. Describe a lonely landscape using weather inside the narrator and a single strong shape.

3. Open a fantasy story with a universal rule and one exception.

4. Show fear without writing afraid, scared or terrified.

5. Make an ordinary object feel mysterious using colour, capitalisation and restraint.

6. Describe a quarrel beginning as if something has been unleashed.
